



VGH-Virtual Cardiac Rehab (VCR) Program

Exercise Program Introduction – Your First Week

Welcome to your first Virtual Cardiac Rehab week. Here are some tips to guide you through our weekly exercise program suggestions:

1. Choose a time of day and day of the week that works best for you to exercise. It is suggested that you stick with a similar time each day as this will help you carve out a regular exercise routine.
2. Record at least 1 of your exercise sessions in the Activity Log provided. Your Case Manager will use your activity log to continue providing you with guidance and feedback about your progress. **Please send your activity log by Friday each week for review. Please reach out to your Case Manager at any time if you are having difficulties with your exercise routine.**
3. The exercise program is divided into:
 - a. Warm Up: Remember, this is a very important part of any exercise session. Do not skip this!
 - b. Aerobic Exercise to train your cardiovascular and respiratory system.
 - c. Resistance Exercise to train your muscles, joints and bones.
 - d. Cool Down: Remember, this is a very important part of any exercise session. Do not skip this!
 - e. You can choose a single or a combination of exercises (but always warm up and cool down). For example: Only do aerobic exercise for day 1, only do resistance training for day 2. As you progress through your program, you can try doing both in one session.
4. Watch the videos first to see how you can set up your exercise space, equipment (water bottles, soup cans) if needed, etc.
5. The Aerobics Exercise Session can be done at least 5 days per week. It can also be done in addition to regular walking. If you are new to exercise, choose 2 or 3 days in the week. Your Case Manager will provide more individualized advice.
6. The Resistance Training Session is offered in video or in print (graphics). These can be done 2-3 days per week, with at least 1 day of rest in between sessions. Speak to your Case Manager for more individualized advice.
7. The Cool Down includes stretches and flexibility exercises that can be done daily.
8. **Please review the VGH-Virtual Cardiac Rehab Program Manual for important information about your program.**



VGH-Virtual Cardiac Rehab (VCR) Program

Exercise Set – Initial Week

In addition to your regular activities such as walking, try to incorporate these videos to your routine (click on the blue link). If you require any modification to the routines, speak with your case manager.

WARM UP Start with 5 minutes of light activity before starting any exercise routine. This may include a walk around your house, march on the spot and light dynamic movements and stretches.

AEROBIC ROUTINE Refer to the VGH cardiac rehab exercise program section in subsequent pages for basic instructions on exercise intensity, frequency, type and time.

Aerobic Exercise (Standing Option): <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=u08lo0bESJc>

Aerobic Exercise (Seated Option): <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ypk6FwMxHnI>

RESISTANCE TRAINING Refer to the Resistance Training section in subsequent pages for general guidelines. The program has a 4-week cycle: Bodyweight, Dumbbells, Bands and Balance/Posture. If you do not have equipment, omit equipment and simply follow through the movements. You may continue to use equipment you do have and follow previous videos or instructions, if available.

Equipment Required: Bodyweight

Standing Option:

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=yijr9RCdOk&list=PLkETa5i0ewgX6_Dfb5XeraB2bfzornvp5&index=10

Seated Option: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=mndel_NnU7E

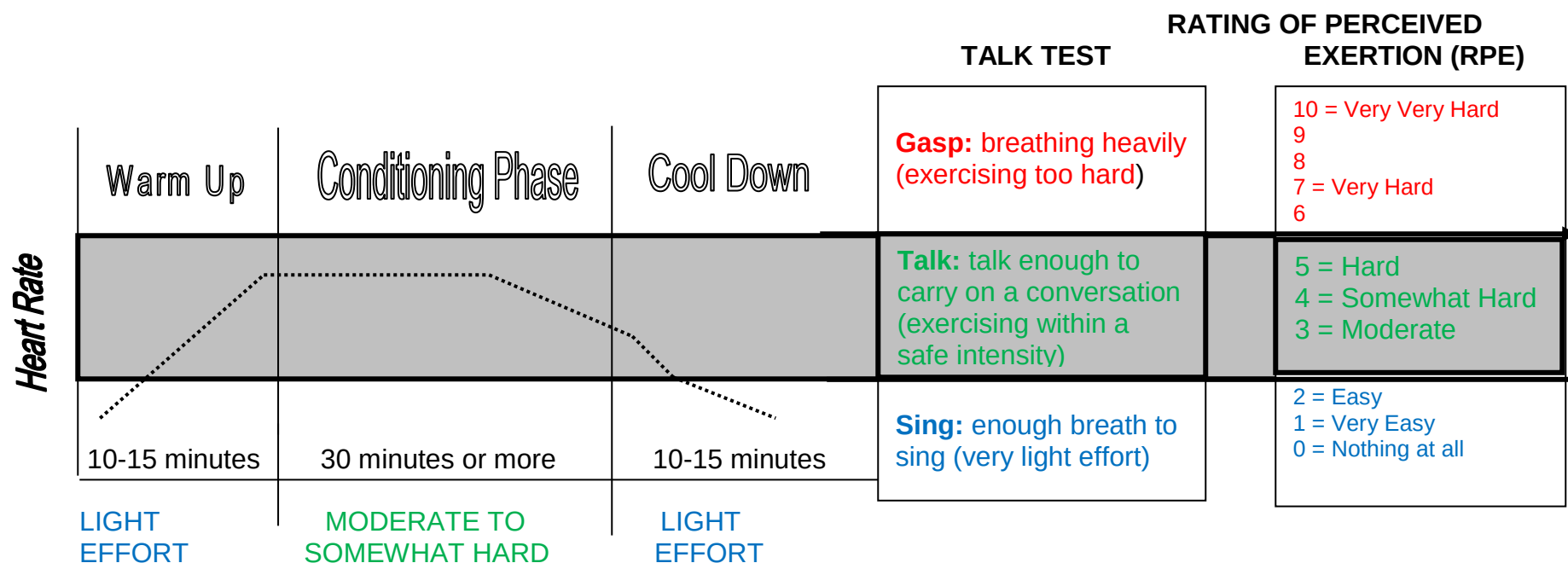
Printed/Graphic exercises: Refer to exercises found on the subsequent pages.

COOL DOWN Suggested stretching routine (printed/graphic exercises) are found on subsequent pages. Perform stretches pain-free, hold each stretch for 20-30 seconds and repeat 2-3 more times.

TIPS ON HOW TO MODIFY YOUR ROUTINE

TOO EASY	TOO HARD
Repeat the routine once more.	Pick one activity to do each day. Day 1: Aerobic; Day 2: Resistance; Day 3: Walk
Do the routine on consecutive days or no more than 1 rest day in between sessions.	Break up your routine through-out the day: Morning: Aerobic; Afternoon: Resistance; Evening Stretch
Combine 2 or 3 routines (Do aerobic, resistance and stretch back-to-back for a full hour of exercise).	Move through-out the day, such as walk around the house or stand more. Any movement is better than no movement.
Build up your volume by exercising more often (5 days/week), and/or longer (30 minutes or more).	Start with the Seated Options before progressing to the Standing Options.
Speak to your Case Manager for more challenging exercise options.	Speak to your Case Manager for less challenging exercise options.

VGH Cardiac Rehab Exercise Program



Frequency: Aim for exercise almost every day (5 days)

Intensity: As above and as tolerated. Listen to your body.

Time: Aim for 30 minutes or more; this can be done in bouts of 10-15 minutes or more.

Type: In home exercise; examples: videos, personal equipment

SIGNALS TO SLOW DOWN:

- ✗ if you have exceeded your target heart rate
- ✗ shortness of breath or difficulty breathing
- ✗ discomfort in chest, arm, back, jaw
- ✗ unusual joint or muscle pain
- ✗ irregular heart beats, dizziness, nausea

For health benefits, adults should accumulate *at least* **150 minutes** of moderate intensity aerobic **physical activity** per week, in bouts of 10 minutes or more. Add muscle and bone strengthening exercises 2 days per week (see General Tips for Strength Training)

General Tips for Strength Training

1. **Always warm up** your body with dynamic movements for 5-10 minutes; e.g. easy walk, light calisthenics and stretches.
2. **Never hold your breath!!** Do not bear down and hold your breath when lifting the weight. Breathe normally through-out the movement.
3. **Learn the movement and technique first.** Practice the movement with good technique and posture without a weight or with a lighter weight. Once you feel you've mastered the technique, add or increase the weight to achieve moderate muscle fatigue **AND** maintain good technique.
4. **Control the movement:** count two seconds to lift the weight and 3 seconds to lower the weight.
5. Choose a *pusher* exercise (chest press, modified push-up), a *puller* exercise (seated row, lat. Pull-downs, band row), and a *leg* exercise (leg press, squat, split squat).
6. **If you can't do 8 (repetitions), decrease the weight.** You should be able to lift your chosen weight comfortably at least 8 times and achieve moderate muscle fatigue with 10-15 repetitions.
7. **Progress in small increments.** Start by adding 1-2 repetitions. Once you can do 15-17 reps, then try adding weight (the smallest increment available) and do 10-15 reps.
8. 1-2 sets of 10-15 repetitions is enough to see improvements in strength when done 2-3 times per week. Be sure to take a day in between strength workouts to recover.
9. **If there's pain, there is no gain!** If a movement is causing pain, try adjusting the weight, position and technique with the help of an exercise professional. If pain continues, stop doing the exercise and seek medical opinion.

Tips for Using Free Weights

- Watch yourself in the mirror to make sure your technique is correct and form is good.
- Be careful when lifting the weight from the rack or the floor. Bend your elbows and your knees; lift with the legs as much as possible.
- Free weights can include dumbbells, water bottles or soup cans etc.

Bodyweight Exercise Routine

Refer to "General Tips for Strength Training" for guidelines.

TIP: If you're new to resistance training, or trying an exercise for the first time, start slowly, for example, 1 set of 10 to 12 repetitions.

- Start with a resistance that feels light, or no resistance at all, until the movement and technique feel easy.
- It helps to watch yourself in the mirror (if possible) to check your technique.
- If you can't do the movement with good technique or without pain, talk to your case manager.

PROGRESSION: Once you feel you've mastered the technique, find a resistance that you can comfortably lift 10 times.

- Gradually increase to 15 repetitions; you can try adding 1-2 repetitions, once every one to two weeks, as tolerated - listen to your body.
- Remember, it should feel moderately challenging, but you should never have to hold your breath or strain to finish your set.
- Once you can do 15+ repetitions, with your current resistance, you can try adding a second set OR increase the resistance by the smallest available increment.
- If you're increasing your resistance, start back at 10-12 repetitions.

Chair Squat (Chair)

Sets: 2-3 | Reps: 12 | Rest: 60s

Preparation:

- Stand in front of a chair or bench, feet shoulder width apart

Execution:

- Perform a squat by bending at the hip
- Stop when your bum touches the chair or bench
- Rise up by straightening at the hip

If required, feel free to push off the arm rests or your legs to help support your as you stand up.

To challenge the exercise, try not to fully sit down and only have your glute touch the chair. You can also perform the exercise by not using a chair.



Start Position



Squat - Bend at the hip, back flat



Knees aligned with toes



Finish Position

Push Up (Wall)

Sets: 2-3 | Reps: 12 | Rest: 60s

Preparation:

- Stand arm-length in front of a wall.
- Palms on the wall at shoulder level.
- Engage core, squeeze glutes.

Execution:

- Imagine your body is a solid plank of wood.
- Lean forward toward the wall, using your arms to control the movement. Touch nose to wall.
- Slowly return to the start position.

Important:

- Keep hips and back straight.

To make this exercise easier, walk your feet closer to the wall.

To make the exercise more challenging:

1) Lift one foot off the ground, perform the push-up for one set. On the next set, lift the opposite foot off the ground and perform the set.

2) If the previous modification was not hard enough, perform the push-up exercise off of a steady table or counter top.



Start position



Push-Up against wall

Scapular Retraction

Sets: 2-3 | Reps: 12 | Rest: 60s

Preparation:

- Sit or stand with good posture
- May be helpful to stand against a wall to feel the movement

Execution:

- Use the muscles between your shoulder blades to pull them together and slightly downward
- Be sure not to pull them together using your trapezius muscles (headache muscles)
- Relax and repeat



Stand tall with shoulders relaxed



Use muscles to squeeze your shoulder blades together and slightly downward; Head stays still

Bridge | Arms Flat

Sets: 2-3 | Reps: 12 | Rest: 60s

Preparation:

- Lie flat on your back with your arms straight beside you
- Bend knees up so that your feet are flat

Execution:

- Lift your hips up in the air to make a bridge using your arms to stabilize
- Lower down in a controlled manner



Start Position



Lift hips up

To make this exercise more challenging, try lifting one foot an inch off the ground and perform the same movement.

Step Up

Sets: 2-3 | Reps: 12 | Rest: 60s

Preparation:

- Stand in front of a box or step

Execution:

- Step up onto the box
- Lower down in a controlled manner
- Repeat, alternating legs

Perform this exercise using the first step of the staircase in your home. If your balance is not the best, ask your case manager for an alternate exercise.

Have a wall or railing beside you for support, step up onto the step completely, then step back down. Repeat on the same foot for the required reps then switch your lead foot and repeat.



Stand in front of box



Step onto box



Rise with control



Lower with control

Four Point + Arm and Leg Raise

Sets: 2-3 | Reps: 12 | Rest: 60s

Preparation:

- Start on hands and knees, hips and shoulders at 90°

Execution:

- Lift one arm straight out in front
- At the same time, lift opposite leg straight back

To make this exercise easier, you can try the following:

1) Modification 1: Try lifting only one arm out in front of your body at a time (leave legs on the ground). Perform for 2-3 sets.

2) Modification 2: Try extending 1 leg straight back at a time (keep arm's fixed on the ground). Perform 2-3 sets.

3) Modification 3: If getting onto the ground is too challenging, perform the modified version using a chair (speak with your case manager about this modification).



Start Position



Lift one arm straight out front and lift the opposite leg straight back



Return to start



Repeat on the opposite side

Full Tandem (Wall)

Sets: 3-5 | Hold: 15-30s

Preparation:

- Stand in a hallway with the fingertips of one, or both, hands resting on a wall

Execution:

- Place the feet 'heel to toe' with the left foot forward
- Steady yourself in this position

Perform a static hold for 15-30s using a wall or chair for support if you require it. Next switch your lead foot and perform another 15-30s hold. This is considered one set, perform this for a total of 3-5 sets.



Stand with feet inline

Stretching Routine

Perform this routine throughout the week to reduce joint stiffness. Remember the stretch should not be painful. Speak with your case manager if you require any modifications. Remember to breathe!

Posterior Shoulder Stretch

Sets: 2-3 | Hold: 30-60s

Preparation:

- Sit or stand with good posture

Execution:

- Reach across your chest
- Use your other arm to pull a bit further



*Head and eyes forward,
belly button pulled in*



Reach arm across body



*Place opposite hand at
elbow, gradually pull to
stretch the back of your
shoulder*

Rhomboid Stretch

Sets: 2-3 | Hold: 30-60s

Preparation

- Clasp your hands in front of you at shoulder height

Execution:

- Push your hands away from your body
- At the same time pull your shoulders towards your hands
- You should feel a stretch in your upper back



Claps hands



*Push hands and
shoulders forward*

Upper Trapezius Stretch | Overpressure

Sets: 2-3 | Hold: 30-60s

Preparation:

- Sit on your hand on the side to be stretched
- Alternatively, you can grab under chair

Execution:

- Bring your chin to chest and look to opposite corner, angling your ear toward your armpit
- To feel an increased stretch, use your opposite hand to guide your head further into the stretch



Start position



Ear to armpit

Swimmer's Stretch

Sets: 2-3 | Hold: 30-60s

Execution:

- Lock fingers behind back; elbows straight
- To increase the stretch, lift your arms backward



*Lock fingers behind back
- To increase the stretch,
lift your arms backward*

Hamstring Stretch

Sets: 2-3 | Hold: 30-60s

Preparation:

- Sit on the edge of a chair

Execution:

- Put one leg out front
- Keep your knee locked
- Lean forward from the hips
- You should feel a stretch in the back of your leg



*Eyes and head forward,
hands resting on thigh,
toes toward the ceiling*



*Hinge at hips to feel
stretch in the back of the
thigh*

Quadriceps Stretch (Chair)

Sets: 2-3 | Hold: 30-60s

Preparation:

- Stand behind a chair

Execution:

- Lift your heel towards your buttock and hold the top of your ankle with your hand, balancing on one leg
- Straighten your hip to increase the stretch across the top of your thigh



*Pull heel to buttocks -
avoid arching back*

Piriformis Stretch - Bottom Leg Straight

Sets: 2-3 | Hold: 30-60s

Preparation:

- Lie on back

Execution:

- Bring knee towards your opposite shoulder



Start Position



Grab knee with hands



Bring knee toward opposite shoulder

Calf Stretch Foot on Wall

Sets: 2-3 | Hold: 30-60s

Preparation:

- Stand close to a wall
- Place bottom of foot up on the wall
- Heel is on the floor

Execution:

- Lean forward until you feel a stretch in your calf



Toes against wall, heel on floor, lean forward